

World History Primary Source Analysis

A reusable toolkit for analyzing any document, image, or map. Works in every unit, all year.

WHAT'S INSIDE

Written Source

HIPP analysis for any text: speech, letter, treaty, account.

Visual Source

Read maps, art, photos, and political cartoons like a historian.

Putting It Together

Group documents and build an evidence-based claim (DBQ-ready).

How to use it

Print the page you need, or assign it digitally. Drop in ANY source from your textbook or unit. These organizers are source-agnostic, so one toolkit covers Ancient River Valleys through the modern era. No prep, no cutting.

Why it works

Historical thinking is a skill, not a fact. These organizers force the moves that separate strong students from passive readers: sourcing, contextualizing, corroborating. Use them often and document analysis stops being scary.

Analyzing a Written Source

Use with any text document. The HIPPP method: Historical context, Intended audience, Point of view, Purpose.

Source

Title / author / date of the document you are analyzing:

H · Historical Context

What was happening in the world when this was written? Why then?

I · Intended Audience

Who was meant to read or hear this? How does that shape it?

P · Point of View

Who is the author? What is their position, background, or bias?

P · Purpose

Why did the author create this? What did they want to happen?

So what?

In one sentence: what does this source reveal about its time that a textbook summary would miss?

Analyzing a Visual Source

Use with maps, paintings, photographs, propaganda posters, and political cartoons.

Source

What is it, and who made it / when?

Observe

List 5 specific details you actually see: people, symbols, words, places, colors. No guessing yet.

Interpret

What is the creator trying to say or show? What clues from 'Observe' tell you?

Significance

How does this source help you understand the event, society, or idea behind it?

Cartoon & propaganda tip

Look for exaggeration, symbols, and a target. Every political cartoon makes ONE argument. Name it in a sentence, then find the detail that proves it.

Putting Sources Together

For document-based questions (DBQs) and any task that uses more than one source.

STEP 1 · SORT

List your documents and what each one shows. Then look for documents that agree, disagree, or add a new angle.

Documents & main idea

Doc A, Doc B, Doc C: write one phrase for each.

STEP 2 · GROUP

Agree

Which sources support the same point? That's a body paragraph.

Complicate

Which source pushes back or adds nuance? Strong essays use this.

STEP 3 · CLAIM

Your thesis

Answer the question in one arguable sentence that you can defend with the documents above.

Use evidence, don't summarize

Quote or cite a specific detail, then explain what it proves. 'Document B shows ____, which means ____.' That move earns the points.

Teacher Guide

Three ways to drop this into your week, no prep required.

Bell-ringer

Project one source. Students do the matching organizer in the first 7 minutes.

Stations

Put a different source at each table. Students rotate with the organizer.

Exam prep

Use the 'Putting Sources Together' page to scaffold DBQ practice before a test.

IF YOU FOUND THIS USEFUL

Full-year curricula, ready to teach

Our store has complete, exam-aligned secondary social studies and AP curricula, including the document sets and DBQ practice these organizers prepare students for. Slides, guided notes, and answer keys, all print-and-teach. Search The Macs' Learning Co. on TPT.

Thank you for downloading. If these organizers help your class, a quick rating helps other teachers find them too.